

Strategic Advisor Frameworks: A Comprehensive Guide

This educational document outlines four core frameworks designed to help advisors strategically position themselves, secure meaningful engagements, and accurately assess client needs.

1. The Three Engagement Types

Benefits: This template clarifies the nature of your client relationship by categorizing work into Advice, Facilitation, or Education. It ensures that engagements are driven by the desire to do the job properly and achieve better client outcomes, rather than just up-selling.

How it helps the business owner: It provides clear expectations. Depending on their needs, the client receives distinct value: acceptance of advice for clear consequences, handling of a trigger event with global and local relevance, or sequential comprehension to close a knowledge gap.

How it helps the advisor: It defines the advisor's position (e.g., Hierarchical for Advice, Professionally Detached for Facilitation) and delivery imperative. It also encourages advisors to "Look Both Ways" (pre-event causes and post-event effects) to extend the engagement arena naturally.

Suitable for: Clients experiencing specific trigger events (like loan drawdowns), knowledge gaps, or situations requiring direct advice.

Step-by-Step Method:

1. **Identify the Driver:** Determine if the client is facing a clear consequence, a trigger event, or a knowledge gap.
2. **Determine the Engagement Type:** Categorize the work as Advice, Facilitation, or Education.
3. **Look Both Ways:** Examine the "cause/pre" (e.g., feasibility of a loan) and "effect/post" (e.g., management meetings post-drawdown) of the client's event.
4. **Deliver on the Imperative:** Execute the work prioritizing accuracy (for advice), the 'reveal' (for facilitation), or chunking (for education).

2. Capacity, Capability, Opportunity (CCO)

Benefits: CCO provides a structured lens to evaluate how a business can realistically grow.

How it helps the business owner: It clearly separates the physical bottlenecks of their business (capacity) from their skill and financial limitations (capability), and ensures they aren't ignoring market realities (opportunity).

How it helps the advisor: It can be used as an internal diagnostic tool to find areas to add value, or as a formal agenda structure to guide a client discussion. It acts as a perfect entry point to tease service offerings without solving all the client's problems on the spot.

Suitable for: Businesses aiming to scale, increase transaction volumes, or move into new premium markets.

Step-by-Step Method:

1. **Frame the Discussion:** Introduce the framework formally as an agenda item, or internally assess the client's status.
2. **Assess Capacity:** Evaluate if they can physically produce more or handle higher transactional volume (e.g., checking downtime or machinery limits).
3. **Assess Capability:** Evaluate if they have the skills, personnel depth, and financial resources/funding to support the growth.
4. **Assess Opportunity:** Look for proof of strong market demand from existing or new clients before proceeding.

3. The Helicopter Story

Benefits: This framework uses a powerful visual analogy to dismantle the flawed logic of "once a year" accounting meetings.

How it helps the business owner: It helps them visualize their business (the helicopter) navigating a volatile economy (wavy ground and storms). It reveals how dangerous it is to fly "blindfolded" without accurate, timely internal dashboards.

How it helps the advisor: It perfectly positions the advisor as the essential "Air Control Tower". By highlighting the risks of high-impact events or internal fraud (3-ton loads), it allows the advisor to naturally ask for more frequent strategic meetings.

Suitable for: Clients who view accounting as an annual compliance exercise and resist regular advisory check-ins.

Step-by-Step Method:

1. **Draw the Scene:** Illustrate a wavy ground (representing high frequency/low impact seasonal volatility) and a mountain (high impact events).
2. **Introduce the Helicopter:** Explain that the helicopter is the business, the pilot is the owner, and the dashboard is their internal reporting.
3. **Apply the Blindfold:** Show how inaccurate or untimely data puts a blindfold on the pilot.

4. **Position the Control Tower:** Draw the control tower (the advisor) and ask, "What use is the control tower if the pilot only calls once a year?".
5. **Secure the Meeting:** Ask the client how often they feel they should meet to discuss their strategic flight plan.

4. Mastering Positioning

Benefits: This template teaches how to move from being a transactional "vendor of hours" to a collaborative "trusted authority".

How it helps the business owner: It creates a safe, trusted environment where their biological survival mechanisms are not triggered. They can relax, knowing their advisor is authentic and on their side.

How it helps the advisor: It shifts the focus from selling a specific product to "selling yourself". By achieving total congruence, it removes friction from the advisory process, making influence much easier.

Suitable for: All prospect and client interactions, especially initial meetings where trust and authority are still being established.

Step-by-Step Method:

1. **Focus on the Client's Mind:** Set your strategic intent to occupy a space of trust and authority before you ever open a spreadsheet.
2. **Align Your Delivery (Congruence):** Ensure your technical advice perfectly matches your body language, tone of voice, and fundamental values.
3. **Monitor the Vibe:** Be aware that a poor vibe can trigger the client's chemical survival response (norepinephrine), making them skeptical and defensive.
4. **Establish the Somatic Connection:** Aim for the unspoken feeling of alignment so the client relaxes and true collaborative influence begins.

Common Q&A

1. Q: Does the CCO framework need to be formally presented to the client every time?

A: No, CCO can be used externally to frame an agenda, but it is equally effective as an internal framework you use to assess a business and find areas where you can add value.

2. Q: Should I use the Helicopter Story to sell additional financial products?

A: No, the Helicopter Story is about securing regular strategic meetings to review the client's "flight plan" and foresee potential problems, moving away from a flawed once-a-year mentality.

3. Q: How does "Positioning" differ from a standard sales pitch?

A: A sales pitch focuses on what you do (the service). Positioning is about who you are in the mind of the client; it is the selling of yourself based on trust, authority, and alignment.

4. Q: What happens if my advice is logically sound, but my positioning is incongruent?

A: Trust is biological. If your tone or body language triggers a survival response (a poor vibe), the client will become defensive and risk-averse; the logic of your advice won't matter.

5. Q: How can I naturally expand an engagement without making the client feel "up-sold"?

A: By using the "Look Both Ways" approach. When a client approaches you with an event (like a loan), you naturally examine the pre-event causes (feasibility) and post-event effects (management meetings) to ensure better client outcomes.

6. Q: What does 'Capacity' actually mean in the CCO framework?

A: Capacity strictly refers to the business's ability for transactional volume. This means evaluating if they have the physical room, machinery, or non-bottlenecked team availability to scale up.

Source Summary Table

Template Name	Core Focus & Contents
3 Types of Engagements	Framework defining Advice, Facilitation, and Education engagements. Focuses on avoiding forced up-selling by analyzing pre-event causes and post-event effects ("Look Both Ways") for better client outcomes.
Advisore_CCO_Tutorial	The Capacity, Capability, Opportunity (CCO) framework. Used internally or externally to assess a business's transactional volume limits, skill depth/funding, and market demand to facilitate growth.
Helicopter Story	A visual analogy demonstrating the risks of infrequent (annual) accounting meetings. Uses a helicopter, pilot, and wavy ground to explain business volatility and position the advisor as an essential "Control Tower".
Positioning	A behavioral guide on shifting from selling a service to selling yourself. Focuses on achieving 'Congruence' (aligning tone, body language, and advice) to build biological trust and trusted authority status.